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CHARTING THE DOCTRINE IN THE COLONIAL ARCHIVE: PAPAL BULLS AND THE TRANSLATION OF THE 'DISCOVERY' PURPOSE

Abstract

The following chapter is intended to give an overview over the role and function of a particular set of papal bulls that together helped define the Doctrine of Christian Discovery, an ideology that, as a precursor of international law, helped define the rules of European colonial conquest. The chapter will explain the evolution of this Doctrine as a dialectical process between worldviews and positions of the papacy and the Iberian monarchies and the progressing results of the 'discovery' process, that is, the early process of European overseas expansion. Through selective close reading of the bulls' texts, I will then focus on the bulls' central contribution to the DoCD, which I see in the transformation of the crusade idea and the Church's mission for the salvation of all souls into a global colonial strategy and, 'en passant,' the global dispossession of indigenous peoples. In synthesis, I will at the end present the Doctrine of Christian Discovery as a 3-step argument as I see it repeatedly being made, adapted, and refined in this set of papal bulls.

Keywords: *Doctrine of Christian Discovery, colonialism, papal bulls, crusade ideology*

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Introduction or the Need for a Papal Bulls Compendium

This year marks the 200th anniversary of a land-claim decision (Johnson v. M'Intosh) of the United States Supreme Court that established the precedent and guiding legal framework for the purchase and ultimately the incorporation of Indigenous territory into the United States. With this landmark decision began the young Republic's "Conquest by Law" of Native America, to borrow from legal scholar Lindsay Robertson.[1] The underlying principle along which Chief Justice Marshall argued the Court's decision was that of the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (DoCD). As a precursor of international law, this fundamentally theological discovery doctrine guided European colonizing powers on the principle that every 'discovered' piece of land that was not ruled by a Christian prince was to be considered *terra nullius* ('no-man's-land') and therefore up for the taking. Within the territory of the US, British title and authority, so the Court's argument, were later transferred to the newly formed United States, establishing the DoCD thereby as the foundational principle of American Indian Law (to this day).[2] However, this DoCD was originally not developed in colonial charters, but in a series of papal bulls issued mainly during the 15th and the early 16th century for the Crowns of Portugal and Castile. To follow the spirit of this Discovery Doctrine from today's issues 'up-river' all the way to its primary source(s), Indigenous activists, their allies, and Indian Law scholars have increasingly turned to the 'archive,' scrutinizing the colonial documents that established, repurposed, and perpetuated this Doctrine to understand its genesis and original meaning. Access to these centuries-old Latin primary sources requires an up-to-date and annotated English translation in an ideally bilingual edition that facilitates the user's navigation between text, translation, and context. In collaboration with Melissa Smith and in coordination with other members of Syracuse University's Doctrine of Discovery Research Team[3]I have been at work at a compendium project featuring the relevant papal bulls in their original Latin and new English translations side by side, as well as introductions and annotations documenting the Doctrine's genesis and the bulls' intertextuality. The following chapter is intended to give an overview over the role and function of a particular set of papal bulls within their historic contexts. Through selective close reading of the bulls' texts, it will

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[1] Lindsay G. Robertson, *Conquest by Law: How the Discovery of America Dispossessed Indigenous Peoples of Their Lands* (Oxford University Press, 2005).

[2] Philip P. Arnold, Sandra L. Bigtree, and Adam DJ Brett, "Introduction to the 200 Years of Johnson v. M'Intosh: Law, Religion, and Native American Lands Series," Canopy Forum: On the Interactions of Law & Religion, March 10, 2023, https://canopyforum.org/2023/03/10/introduction-to-the-200-years-of-johnson-v-mintosh-law-religion-and-native-american-lands-series/; Thomas McMahon, The Great Commission, Papal Bulls and the Doctrine of Discovery: From the 4th Century to Current Law (SSRN, 2021), https://ssrn.com/abstract=3911636 or http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.3805447; Robert J. Miller, "The Doctrine of Discovery: The International Law of Colonialism," The Indigenous Peoples' Journal of Law, Culture, & Resistance 5 (2019): 35–42, https://doi.org/10.5070/P651043048; Robert J. Miller, "The International Law of Colonialism: Johnson v M'Intosh and the Doctrine of Discovery Applied Worldwide," Canopy Forum: On the Interactions of Law & Religion, March 30, 2023, https://canopyforum.org/2023/03/30/the-international-law-of-colonialism-johnson-v-mintosh-and-the-doctrine-of-discovery-applied-worldwide; Steven T. Newcomb, Pagans in the Promised Land: Decoding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (Fulcrum, 2008).

[3] I would like to thank my Syracuse team members Philip Arnold, Sandy Bigtree, Adam DJ Brett, and Betty Hill (Lyons) and the participants of the two Indigenous Peoples and Religious Modes of Othering workshops at the Max Planck Institute for the Study of Religious and Ethnic Diversity, Göttingen and the Diversity Studies Centre Oslo (DISCO), Oslo Metropolitan University (May 24 & 31, 2023), the participants of the The Religious Origins of White Supremacy conference in Syracuse (Dec. 8–10, 2023), as well as the participants of the Haudenosaunee and Indigenous Perspectives on Tracing the Doctrine of Christian Discovery through British Colonial Sources workshop at the British National Archives for all the feedback I have received on previous versions of my views on this topic. I would also like to thank Amy Nelson for her improvement suggestions on an earlier draft of this chapter.

then focus on the bulls' central contribution to the DoCD, which I see in the transformation of the crusade idea and the Church's mission for the salvation of all souls into a global colonial strategy. The Doctrine of Christian Discovery, as I will attempt to show in this chapter, boils down to a 3-step argument that is religious in its reasoning but political in its implications, turning the possibility of discovery into an imperative of conquest.

What is a papal bull?

A papal bull is a type of document usually carrying a form of papal decree, ordinance, or proclamation. The term "bull" as denominator of this document type is a modern convention derived from the attached wax or metal seal (*bulla*), one of the usual means of authenticating an official document. *Bulla* itself is derived from the Latin verb *bullire*, meaning "to melt" or "boil," a clear reference to the seal's creation process. A bull is technically a hybrid between a decree of privilege and a papal letter.[4] However, the papal documents refer to themselves usually as *litter(a)e apostolic(a)e* (apostolic letter) or occasionally in a more general sense as *instrumentum* (document).[5]

The DoCD bulls in their historic context

The DoCD as a 'world view' question

It is now time to turn to this particular set of papal bulls that developed what we have come to call the Doctrine of Christian Discovery. However, before discussing the core tenets of this Doctrine as I see them, it seems important to take a step back and first get a better understanding of the worldview whence they emanated. By 'worldview,' I mean not only the lens of an ideology that is a certain value-guided, macro-level perception of the world, but also the state of geographical knowledge that informed strategic decisions. How did the people who solicited and who created these 15th century bulls see the world at large? From a modern western vantage point, it would seem proper to distinguish a spiritual/religious sphere of perception and beliefs from a scientific, a political, and an economic one, but as our discussion of the Doctrine's core tenets will show, all these spheres are greatly intertwined, and it is often hard to establish where one ends and the other one begins.

On the spiritual level and despite dissent over details, the European medieval and early-modern worldview was dominated by the belief that the faith in Jesus Christ as the crucified son of God is the *condicio sine qua non* for the salvation of the soul. This resulted in a dualistic view of the world between the forces of good (read 'correct,' which is to say 'Catholic,' believers) and the forces of evil that opposed the expansion of Christendom. Traditionally applied to any form of 'pagan' belief systems, the latter role was predominantly played by the cultures of Islam in this medieval world view, at least since the beginnings of the crusades in the late 11th century. In the West, that is, on the Iberian Peninsula, the 'forces of good' appeared to make slow but steady progress over the centuries in their *Reconquista* (re-conquest) of formerly Christian territories. In addition, Popes such as Celestine III (1195), but also northern German chroniclers such as Helmold of Bosau and Arnold of Lubeck, will in the 12th and early 13th centuries frame the attacks and conquests of Slavic and Baltic territories in northeastern

[4] Thomas Frenz, Papsturkunden des Mittelalters und der Neuzeit (Franz Steiner Verlag, 1986).

[5] Frenz, Papsturkunden des Mittelalters, 23

Europe as crusades and perceive the holy wars in the Southeast, the Northeast, and the West as one necessary and coordinated expansion of Christendom against its 'heathen' foes. [6]

Very different was the picture in the East, however, where, after the success of the First Crusade (1096–99) and the establishment of the crusader states in Palestine and parts of Syria, Christian forces were largely on the defense until, with the fall of Acre in 1291, Latin Christendom had lost its last major foothold in the region. With the rise of the Ottoman Empire came not only Christendom's holiest sites ever more closely under Muslim control, but Christian Europe itself came under attack, and the Catholic Church's care for all souls must have seemed more aspirational than realizable. The introductory paragraph (*arrenga*) of the papal bull *Dum Diversas*, for example, promulgated by Nicholas V in 1452—that is, only two years before the fall of Constantinople—in response to recent Portuguese 'discoveries' along the coast of Guinea exposes this dualistic worldview and gives a sense of the papacy's growing panic over Muslim successes:

Dum diversas […] curas, […] in mente revolvimus, illam nobis potissime gerimus precordiis solicitudinem ut Christi nominis inimicorum rabies Christi fidelibus in orthodoxe vilipendium fidei semper infesta reprimi christianeque religioni valeat subiugari	While we […] ponder various concerns […] this is the concern we carry closest to our heart: that the ever-hostile rage of the enemies of Christ's name, who are contemptuous of the correct faith, can be contained by the believers in Christ and subjugated to the Christian Religion;[7]

Dum Diversas, 1452

With the fall of Constantinople vanished the longest-living and once so powerful Christian empire, the Byzantine Empire, which sent spiritual shock waves through Western Christendom. With the continued Muslim successes in the eastern and southern Mediterranean also came a virtual monopoly of Muslim merchants on eastern trade. European producers had almost nothing to offer in return for the desired goods from East Asia, which resulted in extraordinarily high prices and a constant and economically dangerous drain of precious metals from Europe. On the macro-, that is, the worldview-level, at least, it must have appeared that the economic, political, and spiritual adversaries of European Christendom were all the same. With the eastern ends of the Silk Road controlled by the Mongols or various Muslim kingdoms, Western Christians had been turning their strategic as well as commercial interests westward since at least the late Middle Ages. As historian John France notes, "[t]he heavy traffic through the Straits of Gibraltar created an interest in the geographic knowledge of the ancient world, for Greece and Rome had known that there were islands in the Eastern Atlantic."[8]

At the turn from the Late Middle Ages to the Renaissance, cartographers started to merge the wisdom of the ancients with new empirical knowledge of contemporary seafarers. Mapmaking

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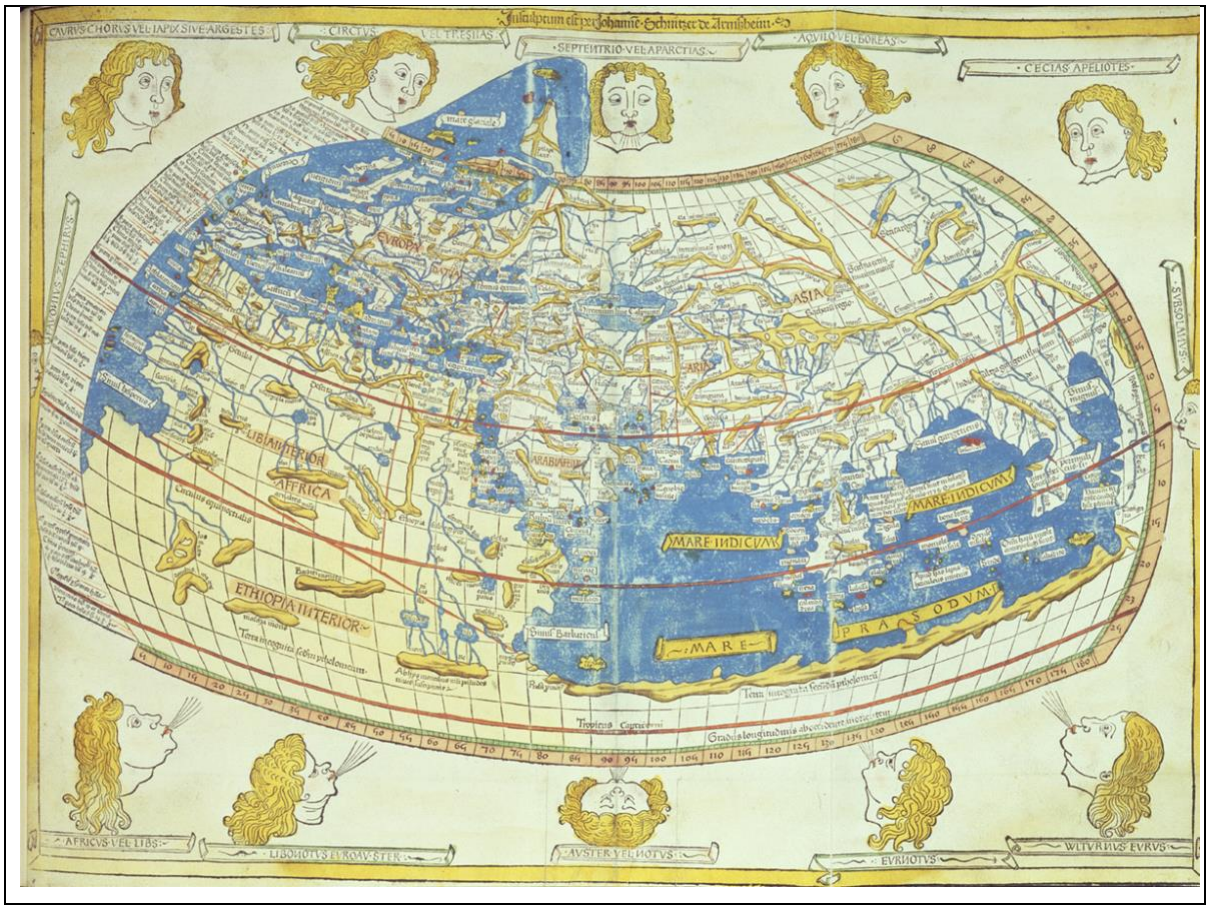
[6] Graham A. Loud, *The Chronicle of Arnold of Lübeck* (Routledge, 2019), 18. With references to the chronicles of Helmold of Bosau (1.59–62) and Arnold of Lubeck (5.30).

[7] All bull translations by Sebastian Modrow and Melissa Smith unless specified otherwise. All emphasis is my own. Certain Latin spelling conventions such as the use of pre-/intervocalic "v" vs. "u" or "ii" vs. "ij" has been unified across citations in this chapter regardless of their rendering in the source edition.

[8] John France, The Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 1000–1714 (Routledge, 2005), 207.

as part of an 'informed call' for a renewal of the crusades to the Holy Land after the fall of Acre is represented in the Venetian Marino Sanudo Torsello's *Liber Secretorum Fidelium Crucis* (*Book of the Secrets of the Faithful of the Cross*, final version from 1321), a representative of the so-called 'recovery literature.' Half a century later, the Catalan Atlas of 1375 would provide a *mappa mundi*, a map of the (whole known) world. However, it was ultimately a work that had been lost to the Western intellectual tradition during the whole Middle Ages that would come to represent the 'state of the art' of geographic knowledge of the 15th century, the century of the ultimate formation of the DoCD: Written in ancient Alexandria in the second century BCE and re-introduced to Europe in a 1410 Latin translation, the *Geographia* (Geography) of Claudius Ptolemy (after 83–after 161 CE) was, among other things, a "guide to making maps [...]. [It] included instructions for making map projections of the world […] and a list of coordinates for some eight thousand places."[9] As Geography scholar Norman Thrower states, "Ptolemy was the ultimate authority on cartography (and astronomy) at the beginning of the great European overseas geographical discoveries of the Renaissance."[10] Ptolemy's view of the world had, however, two fundamental flaws, one of which would become obvious with Portuguese 'discoveries,' and the other one became the precondition for the first voyage of Columbus for the crown of Castile, which in turn would deliver the ultimate proof for the flaw itself (though realized only later). The first was Ptolemy's perception of the Indian Ocean as a land-locked body of water, as can be seen on early prints of Ptolemaic maps as in Leinhart Holle's famous "Ulm Ptolemy" of 1482 (figure 1),



[9] Norman J. W. Thrower, Maps and Civilization: Cartography in Culture and Society, 2nd ed. (University of Chicago Press, 1996), 23.

[10] Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 24.

Figure 1: A map from Leinhart Holle's 1482 "Ulm Ptolemy," an edition of emendations by Nicolaus Germanus to Jacobus Angelus's 1406 Latin translation of Ptolemy's *Geographia* or *Cosmographia* (Alexandria, 2nd cent. CE). Credit: British Library

a view that would erode quickly in the course of the 15th century as European, and in particular Portuguese, ships pushed further south along the West African coast, as discussed below.

The second flaw was Ptolemy's adherence to the globe's circumference as calculated by the second century BCE astronomer, geographer, and historian Poseidonius of Apameia (c. 135–51 BCE) diverging from the nearly correct calculation of Ptolemy's Alexandrian predecessor Eratosthenes of Cyrene (c. 284–c. 202 BCE). Poseidonius had calculated said circumference at about 180,000 stades (c. 17,638 miles), which is only about three quarters of its actual length.[11] On a globe this small, it must indeed have appeared that Japan and southeast China (Marco Polo's 'Cipango' and 'Cathay') as well as India could be reached 'fairly quickly' sailing west.

Only a decade after the "Ulm Ptolemy," Martin Behaim of Nuremberg would publish the first globe called *Erdapfel* ('earth apple') in the same year Columbus embarked on his first voyage (1492), a depiction of the world that would show the southern tip of Africa, Madagascar, India and modern-day Indonesia all separated by an Indian Ocean that (unlike Ptolemy's) *opened* into the great Oceanus. In c. 1500, Juan de la Cosa, possibly the owner and master of Columbus's first flag ship, Santa Maria, drew a portolan-style map (today in the Museo Naval in Madrid) showing Columbian 'discoveries' as well as those made in 1497 along the east coast of North America by an English reconnaissance expedition led by the Venetian Giovanni Caboto (John Cabot) all of which were still believed to be located on the eastern end of Asia. A map "drawn by an anonymous cartographer in Portugal" but later presented to the Duke of Ferrara in Italy by Alberto Cantino (hence its name as Cantino Map) is still showing Cipango (Japan) immediately west of Cuba.[12] The first world map to ever render the western 'discoveries' as a geographically independent (albeit still rather skinny and undefined) American double-continent was the one by Martin Waldseemüller (1507).[13]

I will now make the case that the Discovery Doctrine as it emerges from a series of papal bulls developed precisely out of a worldview that was fueled by an antagonistic crusader mentality and a geographic and geostrategic perception of a world small enough that one could expect to be able to sail west and land in the back of Islam, achieve religious world-domination and ultimately 'free' the Holy Land again by means of discovery and colonization. For that, we need to turn to the argument of the bulls themselves and see this worldview at work in the context of early Iberian colonialism.

From Crusade to Colonial Enterprise

Portuguese 'Crusades'

By the time our bulls in question were issued, Spain and Portugal had been in the 'crusader business' for centuries because the re-conquest (*Reconquista*) of the Iberian Peninsula by Christian forces had been framed and officially recognized as crusade(s) by Pope Calixtus II in

[11] Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 23

[12] Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 69.

[13] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 293; Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 66–67.

1123.[14] The re-conquest of Portuguese territory connected for the first time directly with the re-conquest efforts of the Holy Land during the time of the Second Crusade, when a Flemish, German, and English crusader fleet stopped at Lisbon in 1147 upon invitation of King Afonso I of Portugal and laid siege to the then Muslim-ruled city.[15] Although it is doubtful that Pope Eugene III ever officially ratified this deflection of crusader forces bound for the Holy Land, one of his successors, Alexander III, clearly attested to and applauded the crusading spirit of the Portuguese Reconquista in his bull *Manifestus probatum est* from May 23, 1179.[16]

From the 14th century onward and under the house of Avis, Portugal will develop a form of early modern nation-state with a strong alliance between the crown, the merchant class, and the papacy and will find ways to channel the destructive chivalric energy of its nobility outwards. While Castile was still largely tied up with the last phase of the Iberian Reconquista during the 15th century, it was first the crown of Portugal that invested heavily in the 'discovery' of new territories overseas. A first step was taken in this regard with Portugal's capture of Ceuta (1415) in modern day Morocco: During the reign of John I, his son Duarte embarked on a military expedition into Africa, captured Ceuta on the African site of the straights of Gibraltar, and initiated, thereby, a development that, in the spirit of the medieval crusades, would ultimately evolve into a system of early modern colonization (sugar plantation, quest for gold, slave trade, etc.).[17] Despite its *pro*active features, Portuguese and papal propaganda were still able to frame this attack on Africa as the continuation of the *Re*conquista, that is, the continuation of Christendom's re-conquest attempts of Jerusalem. "Morocco represented, in a certain way," and in the words of Jorge Flores "an extension of the Reconquista and, as a result, became an imperial project highly shaped by war and ideological conflict between Christians and Muslims."[18] Ceuta, however, remained nothing but a Portuguese dot within the vast and still-Muslim-controlled stretches of North Africa, and permanent territorial gains beyond Ceuta proved difficult.

Since the medieval crusades, papal bulls played a central role in the propaganda of the legitimacy of conquest in 'heathen lands.' Only three years after the capture of Ceuta, Martin V issued *Sane Charissimus* (1418). "With this Bull," in the view of Adiele, "the Pope boosted the Portuguese military raids against the Saracens and other non-Christians in West Africa. This Bull is very important in the history of the Portuguese relationship with the papacy which lasted for centuries and their entire trading business in Africa. Its importance lies in the fact that it serves as the first foundational papal Bull in the whole political and economic enterprise of the Portuguese in Africa."[19]

The papacy's legitimizing power is further attested in a passage of a petition by Portugal's King Duarte (Edward) I to Eugenius IV.[20] In regard to the conquest of the non-Christianized parts of the Canary Islands, he states:

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[14] R. A. Fletcher, "Reconquest and Crusade in Spain, c. 1050–1150," in The Crusades: The Essential Readings, ed. Thomas F. Madden (Blackwell, 2002), 63.

[15] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 133–35.

[16] Cf. De Fonseca et al. 2016, 141–142

[17] Lyle N. McAlister, Spain and Portugal in the New World, 1492–1700 (University of Minnesota Press, 1984), 11–13.

[18] Jorge Flores, "The Iberian Empires, 1400 to 1800," in The Construction of a Global World, 1400–1800 CE, Part 1: Foundations, The Cambridge World History, vol. 6, ed. Jerry H. Bentley, Sanjay Subrahmanyam, and Merry E. Wiesner-Hanks (Cambridge University Press, 2015), 275.

[19] Pius Onyemechi Adiele, The Popes, the Catholic Church and the Transatlantic Enslavement of Black Africans, 1418–1839 (Georg Olms Verlag, 2017), 269.

[20] Duarte I, letter to Eugenius IV, August 1436, in Monumenta Henricina, vol. 5, 1434–1436 (Coimbra, 1963), 254–58 (doc. 129).

Quamvis enim infidelium loca propria auctoritate plerique debellare et occupare nitantur, nichilominus, quia Domini est terra et plenitudo eius, qui et sanctitati vestre plenariam orbis tocius potestatem reliquit, que, de auctoritate et permissu sanctitatis vestre, possidebuntur, de speciali licencia et permissione omnipotentis Dei possideri videntur.	"although many strive to conquer and occupy lands of infidels on their own authority, nevertheless, since the earth in its entirety belongs to the Lord, who bequeathed full power over the whole world to your holiness, lands which are held on the authority of your holiness and by your permission are seen to be held by the special license and permission of almighty God.…[21]

Letter of Duarte I to Eugenius IV, 1436

The Portuguese king alludes here to the concept of the *papal world monarchy* which, developed in the 13th century by scholars of canon law, was linked to the Pope's title of "vicar of Christ."[22] Developed in opposition to the claims of the Holy Roman Emperor and never seriously recognized by any secular power, it seems strange, at first, to find such a concession in the petition of a secular ruler. But in the context of the colonization rivalry with Castile— first over the Canary Islands and later globally—it must have seemed advantageous to the Portuguese monarch to align his claim with that of the Pope. James Muldoon could also show how early modern conceptualizations of international law such as Hugo Grotius' *De jure belli ac pacis* (*On the Law of War and Peace*, 1625) are deeply indebted to the medieval canonist tradition (via early modern legal thinkers of the 'Spanish School' at Salamanca, here especially the early 16th century Dominican, Francisco de Vittoria), for example for early *dominium* theory among other things.[23] [24]

By the time of this petition (1436), however, Portuguese focus and strategy had significantly changed: stuck in Ceuta and unable to make any gains with over-land campaigns in North Africa, Portugal turned to the sea. Another Portuguese prince, the *Infante* Henry (later called the "Navigator"), son of King John I, had sent expeditions down the coast of Africa that were as much exploratory as commercial in nature. Lyle McAlister, however, reminds us that "[t]he House of Avis [...] regarded all of them as adjuncts to the Portuguese Crusade, which acquired increasingly grandiose proportions and chimerical objectives. John and his sons hoped that by sailing south they could outflank Islam and establish contact with the legendary Christian kingdom of Prester John, indeterminately located in East Africa or perhaps somewhere in Asia. Along with exploring, trading, and crusading, officially sponsored expeditions took possession of the lands they discovered in the king's name […]".[25] The route to the recovery of the Holy

[21] *Monumenta Henricina*, vol. 5, 254–258, doc. 129. Transl. by Alan Forey, "Papal Claims to Authority over Lands Gained from the Infidel in the Iberian Peninsula and Beyond the Straits of Gibraltar," in Balard, *La Papauté et les croisades / The Papacy and the Crusades*, 133, https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315591261.

[22] Cf. Watt 1964, 179–317; Ullman 1949; Muldoon 2024, 553–580.

[23] James Muldoon, "A Canonistic Contribution to the Formation of International Law," in Canon Law, the Expansion of Europe, and World Order (Routledge, 2024), 273–74, https://doi-org.libezproxy2.syr.edu/10.4324/9781003556497.

[24] Cf. *Muldoon* 273–274, 484 for the early modern discussion of the controversial medieval canonist position "that non-Christians who refused to accept papal supremacy in temporals could be deprived of their property and lordship" as promoted by the highly influential 13th century canonist Hostiensis, a position that in itself was developed as justification of the crusades along the Roman law concept of the 'just war.'

[25] McAlister, Spain and Portugal in the New World, 47–48.

Land—so, at least, the pretext—lead through and around Africa.[26] "So Henry had a rather typically aristocratic mix of chivalric and religious reasons for interest in exploration. He was also desperately short of money and may well have been, for this reason, attracted by tales of the 'River of Gold'," in the words of John France.[27]

While taking advantage of the 'volta,' the clockwise circular current in the North Atlantic[28] requiring ships returning from the African coast to sail home in a large circle, the Portuguese discovered and soon added the archipelagos of Madeira (1420), the Azores (1432), and later the Cape Verde Islands to their possessions, all of which were uninhabited. This was to change with the conquest attempts of the Canary Islands, which were in fact inhabited by an Indigenous, non-Muslim population.[29] It is unclear how the existence of this archipelago reentered the European consciousness, whether first through 'rediscovery' of these 'Fortunate Islands'[30] in ancient sources or, as France surmises, through adverse winds in the Atlantic. They were supposedly (re)discovered by the Genoese Lancelotto Malocello, and the Canarian Island of Lanzarote still bears his name. What is more certain is that in 1342, a first expedition sailed to the Canaries from Aragon-controlled Majorca but was unable to conquer them.[31] Only a few years later (1344–45), the Castilian nobleman Luis de la Cerda, an expatriate prince of the crown of Castile who served the king of France as admiral, tried again, fortified with Pope Clement VI's formal blessings, the bull *Tue devotionis sinceritas* (November 15, 1344). James Muldoon reminds us that this was not a completely unusual exception at the time but "Clement VI [rather] continued the papal practice of transferring the overlordship of lands held by heretics, schismatics or infidels to secular rulers who promised to reform the state of the Church in such lands or to impose Christianity, a practice that went back to the Gregorian reform."[32] This bull not only framed his expedition as a crusade but declared the Canaries (*Fortunatae Insulae*) a principality and de la Cerda and his heirs immediate vassals of the papacy. Despite accomplishing rather little, he took on the preposterous title of "Prince of Fortuna." Portuguese subjects exploited this *de facto* power vacuum during the later 14th century and were trading and raiding alongside Castilian subjects in the archipelago, often interfering with the proselytizing attempts of the Church, which was also trying to get a firm foothold in the region and to develop its 'spiritual infrastructure.'

Half a century later (1402), the original situation was somewhat reversed when the French noblemen Jean de Bethencourt and Gadifer de la Salle sailed under the Castilian flag, much to Portuguese chagrin. Though not concluded until 1495 with the successful defeat of the Indigenous population of Tenerife, the conquest of the Canaries had begun in earnest.[33] The islands of the Atlantic represent hereby an important step from the anti-Muslim crusade framework towards a truly global Doctrine of Christian Discovery: "On these Atlantic islands,

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[26] Cf. De Fonseca et al., "Papacy and the Crusade," 153; France, *Crusades and Expansion*, 292–293.

[27] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 293.

[28] Cf. Reinhard 2016, 62, 64 for visualization of the Atlantic's winds and currents.

[29] Flores outlines the importance of these early island 'discoveries' for the evolving colonial system: "The islands in the Atlantic – including the Canary Islands, reclaimed and colonized by Castile during the same century – came to serve as indispensable points of support for oceanic navigation and important platforms for the circulation of people, plants, animals and technologies in the Atlantic Ocean and beyond. The archipelagos also assumed the function of imperial laboratories for the Iberian kingdoms. There, for the first time (though anchored in peninsular precedents), royal land grant systems were experimented with." Flores, "Iberian Empires," 275.

[30] See the description of the Fortunate Islands by the ancient (1st cent. CE) authority Pliny the Elder (*Natural History* 6.37).

[31] Wolfgang Reinhard, Die Unterwerfung der Welt: Global Geschichte der europäischen Expansion, 1415–2015 (C. H. Beck, 2016), 79.

[32] Muldoon, "Canonistic Contribution," 129–30

[33] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 207, 292

the first plantation economies were established based on slave labour and involving the production of sugar and other commodities. And it was equally there that relationships with indigenous people who were neither Christians nor Muslims, such as the Guanches in the Canary Islands, were experimented with for the first time."[34]

The ensuing dynamic and the role the bulls of the Popes came to play in this whole process of early colonization in the Atlantic and beyond can only be understood if we reiterate with John France that "[f]or Spain and Portugal it was a continuation of the *Reconquista*, and just as competitive as that process had been."[35] On the Canaries as well as on the African mainland, Christian zeal and Iberian proto-colonial interests happily joined forces, and the Popes gladly branded the endeavors of the Iberian crowns as instruments in this global struggle between the *only true faith* ("faith itself") and its enemies:

ad id quoque, […] nostre libenter diligentie studium impendimus operose necnon singulos christifideles, precipue carissimos in Christo filios reges illustres […] qui […] <u>fidem ipsam defendere ac illius inimicos</u> potenti student brachio <u>expugnare</u>, paterno prosequi teneamur affectu…	to this [cause …] we also zealously devote our unsparing effort and are eager to reach out with fatherly affection to all the believers in Christ, particularly the illustrious Kings […] who strive <u>to defend faith itself</u> […] <u>and to defeat its enemies</u> with their mighty arm… Dum Diversas, 1452

In this crusading spirit and as further incentive, *Dum Diversas*, just like earlier bulls for the Canary Islands, also provides the prospect of full indulgence for all direct and indirect participants:

Nos enim ut tu ac dilecti filii Nobiles viri duces, principes, barones, milites aliique christifideles tuam regiam serenitatem, in hac fidei pugna concomitantes, seu mittentes et de bonis suis contribuentes […] ut confessor ydoneus, […] plenariam remissionem omnium et singulorum peccatorum, criminum, delictorum et excessuum, […] tibi ac eisdem concomitantibus, […] concedere valeat, […] indulgemus.	To enable you and [our] beloved sons, the noble dukes, princes, barons, knights, and other believers in Christ who (either) accompany your Royal serenity in this battle for the faith or who send (help) and contribute from their possessions […] we grant […] that an appropriate confessor […] may bestow upon you and said companions the full remission of each and every sin, reproach, fault, and transgression […]. Dum Diversas, 1452

As the Portuguese 'discovered' their way down the West African coast, and the hope grew that the Indian Ocean (contra Ptolemy!) was not a landlocked body of water and that India could indeed be reached around the southern tip of Africa, this crusader framework was soon adapted into a global strategy. The phrasing of the bulls often reveals this dialectical process between the petitioning royal party and the papacy. Soon after *Dum Diversas* and only two years after the fall of Constantinople to the Muslim Ottomans, the Portuguese crown petitioned (and received) the bull *Romanus Pontifex* (1455), representing not only a further

[34] Flores, "Iberian Empires," 275.

[35] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 292.

specification of Portugal's colonial monopolies on the West-African coast but also an extension of their geographic scope,

credens se maximum in hoc Deo prestare obsequium, si ejus opera et industria mare ipsum usque ad Indos qui Christi nomen colere dicuntur, navigabile fieret, sicque cum eis participare, et illos in Christianorum auxilium adversus Sarracenos et alios hujusmodi fidei hostes commovere posset, ac nonnullos gentiles seu paganos nefandissimi Machometi secta minime infectos populos inibi medio existentes continuo debellare	because he [the Infante Henry the Navigator] believes he would be of greatest service to God in this matter if, through his effort and engagement, this sea became navigable all the way to the Indians who, it is said, worship the name of Christ, and could prompt them thereby to join him and to help the Christians against the Saracens and other such enemies of the faith, and to immediately subdue some of the heathens and pagans there are in between, who are least infected by the sect of the most despicable Mohammed…
	Romanus Pontifex, 1455

As the Doctrine develops, the crusade idea blends almost inseparably with Portuguese interests in commerce and conquest. This strategy was, therefore, not only expedient but also aligned with Church doctrine and the Scriptures themselves. According to the above-outlined worldview, the salvation of all souls depended on the faith in Jesus Christ as lord and savior who himself supposedly encouraged his faithful to bring to him the sheep "which are not of his fold […] and there shall be one fold, and one shepherd,"[36] a foundational metaphor for the understanding of the Christian mission[37] which Nicholas V in *Romanus Pontifex* will integrate into the Discovery Doctrine:

Romanus pontifex, Regni celestis clavigeri successor et Vicarius Jhesu Christi, cuncta mundi climata omniumque nationum in illis degentium qualitates paterna consideratione discutiens, ac salutem querens et appetens singulorum, illa propensa deliberatione salubriter ordinat et disponit que grata Divine Majestati fore conspicit et <u>per que oves sibi divinitus creditas ad unicum ovile dominicum reducat</u>, et acquirat eis felicitatis eterne premium, ac veniam impetret animabus;	The Roman pontiff, successor to the keeper of the keys to the Kingdom of Heaven and vicar of Jesus Christ, examining with his fatherly eye every part of the world and the qualities of all the peoples living therein and looking out for and striving for the welfare of each of them, after careful deliberation in their best interest orders and disposes that which he expects to please the Divine Majesty and <u>by which he may bring back the sheep entrusted to him</u> by divine will into the one fold of the Lord and secure for them the prize of eternal beatitude and obtain indulgence for (their) souls…

[36] John 10:16 (King James Version).

[37] Cf. McMahon 2021, 8–14; Muldoon 2017, 137 for the connection of the 'Great Commission' and European expansion.

Romanus Pontifex, 1455

The subtle nuances are noteworthy, however, and as I will argue, programmatic: While the original Vulgate Latin translation of John 10:16 speaks of *et illas oportet me adducere*, which the King James version renders as "them also I must bring," *Romanus Pontifex* speaks of *reducere*. And while the original *adducere* evokes the movement towards something, *reducere*, in contrast, denotes the 'bringing back' of the sheep that are currently not in the fold. With the concept of the papal world monarchy in the background, this subtle rephrasing is, in my view, in line with the bulls' rendering of adherence to other religions and cultural belief systems as defection from the truth: Any resistance against God's plan by 'clinging' to a belief system that is not the Catholic faith is being viewed as treason and rebellion according to the papal bulls, a rebellion that must be crushed at all costs. We also need to take into account that this Doctrine grew out of the crusade/reconquest tradition aimed primarily at first against Muslim populations who have acknowledged Jesus Christ as prophet but not as (son of) God. *Dum Diversas*, as we just saw, called Islam "the sect of the most despicable Mohammed," a term that implies heresy, that is, knowledge of but defection from/rejection of the proper faith. In the face of such 'resistance' to the true faith, military defeat and political submission are presented as appropriate means to the end of making the kingdom of God a reality for all souls. Directly addressing King Afonso V of Portugal, Pope Nicholas V made this already crystal clear three years earlier in *Dum Diversas*:

Sane, sicut ex pio christianoque desiderio tuo procedere conspicimus, tu Christi inimicos sarracenos videlicet subiugare ac ad Christi fidem potenti manu redigere intendis, si ad id tibi apostolice sedis suffragetur auctoritas.

Nos igitur, considerantes quod contra catholicam fidem insurgentibus christianamque religionem extinguere molientibus, […] est resistendum, ut fideles ipsi, fidei ardore succensi […] nom solum obice intentionis contraire impediant, si ex oppositione roboris iniquos conatus prohibeant et […] perfidorum substernant molimenta nosque, […] ea que fidei, […] integritatem augmentumque respiciunt, […] confouere merito cupientes, tibi sarracenos et paganos aliosque infideles et Christi inimicos, quoscunque et ubicunque constitutos, regna, […] inuadendi, conquerendi, expugnandi, et subiugandi illorumque personas perpetuam seruitutem redigendi, regna quoque, ducatus, comitatus, principatus aliaque dominia, possessiones et bona huiusmodi, tibi et successoribus tuis regibus Portugallie perpetuo applicandi et appropriandi ac in tuos et eorumdem successorum vsus et vtilitates conuertendi, plenam et liberam,

You truly intend, as seems clear to us from your pious and Christian desire, to subjugate Christ's enemies, namely, the Saracens, and to return them with mighty hand to the Christian faith, should you receive from the Apostolic See the authority to do so.

Because we realize that those who rise up against the Catholic faith and plot to eradicate the Christian Religion must be resisted […] such that the believers, burning with passion for the true faith […] should not just obstruct by objecting to the intention to transgress, if they in (their) opposition to force fend off hostile sallies but [...] also thwart the plots of the deceivers,

and because we duly wish […] to foster those things pertaining to the integrity and augmentation of the faith […], we therefore grant you by apostolic authority with the content of the present (letter) the full and unrestricted power to invade, conquer, capture, and subjugate the Saracens, pagans, and other infidels and whichever enemies of Christ and wherever (their) kingdoms, […] may be [… and] to reduce their people to perpetual servitude, and to also forever attach yourself to and appropriate for

auctoritate apostolica, tenore presentium, concedimus facultatem…	yourself and your successor kings of Portugal [said] kingdoms, duchies, counties, principalities, and other dominions, possessions, and such goods and make their use and profits yours and said successors'…

Dum Diversas, 1452

Portugal's explorations and conquests along the West African coast are framed hereby as preemptive strikes in defense against the 'enemies' of the 'true faith' and the beginnings of Atlantic colonization as a continuation of the idea of the crusader states. After initial concerns about the enslavement of the Indigenous population of the Canaries as de facto impediment to their conversion, Nicholas V now seems to reverse this view in application to the West African mainland and supports the perpetual *servitus* of its people.

However, the success of such a 'global crusading strategy,' the Portuguese crown will have made clear, depended on certain political and economic realities that had to be established 'on the way.' *Romanus Pontifex* (1455) goes beyond *Dum Diversas* and cements the Portuguese 'discovery monopoly' on the West African coast and beyond combining this exclusive right to conquest with a trade monopoly as a necessary means towards a higher end, which will now transform this 'crusade' recognizably into a colonial enterprise:

[…] autem […] accepimus, licet rex et Infans prefati, qui cum tot tantisque periculis, laboribus, et expensis, nec non perditione tot naturalium regnorum hujusmodi, quorum inibi quamplures perierunt, […] provincias illas perlustrari fecerunt ac portus, insulas, et maria hujusmodi acquisiverunt et possederunt, ut prefertur, ut illorum veri domini, timentes ne aliqui cupiditate ducti, ad partes illas navigarent, et operis hujusmodi perfectionem, fructum, et laudem sibi usurpare vel saltem impedire cupientes, propterea seu lucri commodo, aut malitia, ferrum, arma, ligamina, aliasque res et bona ad infideles deferri prohibita portarent, vel transmitterent, aut ipsos infideles navigandi modum edocerent, propter que eis hostes fortiores ac duriores fierent, […] non absque Dei magna offensa et ingenti totius Christianitatis obprobrio, ad obviandum premissis ac pro suorum juris et possessionis conservatione, sub certis tunc expressis gravissimis penis prohibuerint et generaliter statuerint quod nullus, nisi cum suis nautis et navibus et certi tributi solutione obtentaque prius desuper expressa ab eodem rege vel	we have heard, however, that aforementioned king and Infante-- who, after so many and great dangers, efforts, and expenses, and loss of people from these kingdoms, of who so many perished there, […] were able to sail through those regions and to thereby acquire and take into possession the ports, islands, and seas, as aforementioned, as their true lords– fearing that others, driven by greed, might sail to those regions and, in their desire to claim the completion, fruit, and glory of this work for themselves, or to sabotage it, at least, might therefore - either for financial gain or out of malice - bring or send iron, arms, timber, and other things and goods that are prohibited to bring to the infidels or teach the infidels the art of sailing, through which their enemies would become stronger and harder to deal with - apart from the great offense against God and the enormous insult to all of Christianity -, in order to prevent the above and for the protection of their right and possession, prohibited under certain then-clearly defined penalties and established in general that no one, unless with their sailors

Infante licentia, ad dictas provincias navigare aut in earum portibus contractare seu in mari piscari presumeret …	and ships and after the payment of a certain tribute and after receiving explicit license from the same king or Infante, may venture to sail to said regions or do business in their ports or fish in the sea …

Romanus Pontifex, 1455

The Pope confirms these exclusive claims of Portugal, a confirmation that Portugal most certainly requested from the papacy, necessitating the issuing of *Romanus Pontifex* only three years after *Dum Diversas*. However, the crusade framework revealed itself even in the commercial aspects of the endeavor: the crown could delegate concessions or patents to private parties as long as they paid the "*quinto* (the royal fifth) to the crown, apparently an overseas adaptation of the Reconquest levy of one-fifth of booty taken."[38] But commercial enterprise and crusade and mission are always intertwined: only one year (and one Pope) later, the first *Inter Caetera* bull[39] will not only confirm *Romanus Pontifex* but also grant the Order of Christ, the successor order to the Knights Templar in Portugal which had always enjoyed especially close relationships with the Portuguese crown, the exclusive right to develop the church infrastructure in the conquered (and to be conquered) territories.

This most favorable position will ultimately allow Portugal to be content with its other archipelagos and, in the Treaty of Alcáçovas (1479, ratified in the next year in Toledo), to formally cede all claims to the Canaries to Castile. By this time, it had firmly established the west coast of Africa and the southern route to India as its sphere of interest, an interest that the Popes Nicholas V and Callixtus III had confirmed as a virtual monopoly with the bulls *Dum Diversas* (June 18, 1452), *Romanus Pontifex* (January 8, 1455), and *Inter Caerera* (March 13, 1456), a monopoly that Castile in turn acknowledged in the same treaty. Both powers, it seems, requested subsequently Rome's confirmation of this first division of the Atlantic world, and either's right to conquest and possession was confirmed by the papal bull *Aeterni Regis* (June 21, 1481), issued by Pope Sixtus IV. This bull, by quoting directly a section of the Treaty of Alcáçovas (in Latin translation), explicitly acknowledges and confirms Castile's concessions

super possessione et quasi possessione, in qua sunt, in omnibus commerciis, terris, et permutationibus sive resignatis Guinee, cum suis mineriis seu aurifodinis, et quibuscunque aliis insulis, littoribus, seu costis maris, terris, […] insulis de la Madera, de Portu Sancto, et Insula Deserta, et omnibus insulis dictis de los Açores […], et insulis Florum, et etiam insulis de Cabo Verde […] et insulis quas nunc invenit, et quibuscunque insulis que deinceps invenientur aut acquirentur, ab insulis de	regarding the possession or quasi-possession, which [the Portuguese] hold over all commercial enterprises, lands of Guinea, qua exchange or ceded, with their ore- and goldmines, and over whatever other islands, coastlines or shores, (and) lands, […] the islands of Madeira, Porto Santo, (Isola) Deserta, and all islands called the Azores […] and the Flores Islands, as well as the islands of Cape Verde, […] and the islands that he just found, and whatever islands will be found or acquired from the Canary Islands

[38] McAlister, Spain and Portugal in the New World, 49.

[39] Calixtus III, 1456.

Canaria ultra et citra et in conspectu Guinee, ita quod quicquid est inventum vel invenietur et acquiretur ultra in dictis terminis, id quod est inventum et detectum remaneat dictis Regi et Principi de Portugallia et suis regnis, exceptis duntaxat insulis de Canaria […], que remanent regnis Castelle …	onwards on either side and along Guinea so that whatever is found or will be found and acquired further within said area, (and) that which has been found and discovered may remain with said King and Prince of Portugal and their kingdoms with the exception only of the Canary Islands […] which remain with the kingdoms of Castile…
	Aeterni Regis, 1481

De Fonseca et al., following Housley, postulate that Iberian imperialism into the Atlantic meant a replacement of the old *recuperatio/defensio fidei* concept (recovery [of territory]/defense of the [Christian] faith) of the 'classical' crusades, which were mainly focused on the Iberian peninsula and the Holy Land, by that of the *dilatio fidei*, i.e., the extension of Christendom through a form of missionary imperialism.[40] For Spain, the end of this transition came with the end of the Iberian Reconquista.

Columbian 'Discoveries' and the never-ending Spanish Reconquista

In this chapter, I argue that the DoCD grew out of crusading ideology, and for the Iberian kingdoms as much as for the crusaders attempting to 'free' the Holy Land, this was explicitly a re-conquest ideology. "The manifest destiny of the Christian states of northern Spain to reconquer the lands lost to the Moors in the eighth century has been a prominent part of the Spanish historical tradition since the thirteenth century," we are reminded by Peter Lock.[41] As mentioned above, in 1123, Pope Calixtus II recognized the re-conquest of the Iberian Peninsula officially as a crusade.[42] For Spain, the term *Reconquista* refers in general to two separate phases of Christian-Muslim warfare. After centuries of stability, the Muslim unity was shattered in the 11th century, which led to two centuries of fighting during which most of the Peninsula was reconquered by the armies of Christian kings. The Christian conquerors would then only occasionally seek the Pope's recognition of their territorial gains.[43] Only the Moorish kingdom of Granada managed to survive for another two centuries, its Nasrid dynasty becoming vassals of the crown of Castile. But after Spain had been united through the marriage of Isabella of Castile and Ferdinand of Aragon, this last Moorish bastion fell in 1492, and it is not accidental that Columbus received his patent in the same year that Spain ran out of Muslim territory to conquer on the peninsula and with the whole West coast of Africa now reserved for Portugal, as we just saw. In the papal bull *Inter Caetera*, issued in 1493 after Columbus' return from his first voyage, Pope Alexander VI frames the new Spanish 'discoveries' in 'Asia' much in the same way as his predecessor Nicholas V had framed the earlier Portuguese ones in Africa:

[40] (Luís Adao de Fonseca, Maria Cristina Pimenta, and Paula Pinto Costa, "The Papacy and the Crusade in XVth Century Portugal," in La Papauté et les croisades / The Papacy and the Crusades, ed. Michel Balard (Ashgate, 2011), 151, https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315591261; Norman Housley, The Later Crusades: From Lyons to Alcazar, 1274–1589 (Oxford University Press, 1992), 309.

[41] Peter Lock, The Routledge Companion to the Crusades (Routledge, 2006), 205.

[42] Fletcher, "Reconquest and Crusade," 63.

[43] Forey, "Papal Claims," 132

Inter cetera divine Maiestati beneplacita opera et cordis n[ost]ri desiderabilia, illud profecto potissimum existit, ut fides catholica et christiana religio nostris presertim temporibus exaltetur ac ubilibet amplietur et dilatetur animarumque salus procuretur ac barbare nationes deprimantur et ad fidem ipsam reducantur.

Among other works pleasing the divine majesty and close to our heart, this indeed stands out the most: elevating the Catholic faith and the Christian religion, especially in [these] our times, as well as extending and spreading it everywhere, securing the salvation of souls and subduing the barbarous nations and bringing them back to the faith itself.

Inter Caetera, May 4, 1493

In between multiple repetitions of the central motive (the spread of Christianity and submission of the 'barbarous nations'), Pope Alexander also explicitly declares these oversea 'explorations' a continuation and extension of the Spanish *Reconquista*:

Sane accepimus quod vos, qui dudum animo proposueratis aliquas insulas et terras firmas, remotas et incognitas ac per alios hactenus non repertas, querere et invenire, ut illarum incolas et habitatores ad colendum Redemptorem nostrum et fidem catholicam profitendum reduceretis, hactenus in expugnatione et recuperatione ip[s]ius Regni Granate plurimum occupati, huiusmodi sanctum et laudabile propositum vestrum ad optatum finem perducere nequivistis; sed tandem, sicut Domino placuit, regno predicto recuperato, volentes desiderium adimplere vestrum, dilectum filium Cristophorum Colon […] destinastis, ut terras / firmas et Insulas remotas et incognitas huiusmodi per mare, ubi hactenus navigatum non fuerat, diligenter inquireret;

We have heard, of course, that though for some time you had intended to look for and find certain remote and unknown islands and mainlands, heretofore undiscovered by others, in order to return their local population and inhabitants to the worship of our Redeemer and to the profession of the Catholic faith, you were not able to reach the intended goal of this your sacred and commendable plan, as you were until now most occupied with the conquest and recovery of the Kingdom of Granada itself; but when the aforementioned kingdom was finally regained, as it pleased the Lord, and wishing to follow your desire, you designated (our) beloved son Christopher Columbus […] to diligently search for remote and unknown continents and islands of this kind across the sea, where no one had ever sailed before;

Inter Caetera, May 4, 1493

In hindsight, it is easy to recognize how the Spanish monarchs and Columbus found each other, because they needed each other since the recent Portuguese monopolies and successes pushed both Spanish Atlantic ambitions and Columbian ideas to the side, as France explains. By the time of Henry the Navigator's death,

the Portuguese had reached Sierra Leone. In 1470–75 they explored the Gulf of Guinea, and in 1483 Diogo Cão reached the Congo river. Joao II (1481–95) pressed on the process of discovery, encouraged by the flow of gold and the slaves from the trading posts and forts established on the West African littoral. At the same time his orders to his captains made clear his desire to tap into the spice-trade by circumnavigating Africa. But the king was also particularly anxious

to find the land of 'Prester John' and this formed part of his instruction to Bartholemew Diaz who in 1488 rounded the Cape of Good Hope, opening the way for the celebrated journey of Vasco da Gama, who, in 1497–99, rounded the Cape, reached Calcutta and returned to Portugal. This remarkable progress towards the 'Indies' probably explains why in 1484 Columbus finally felt that he had no chance of persuading the Portuguese court to support his project to reach the 'Indies' by westward route.[44]

And similarly in the Spanish case, the economic reasons for equipping fleets to sail west towards 'India' are as hard to disentangle from those of mission and crusade. Columbus himself embodied this mix of commercial enterprise and mission, signaled not least in his 'over-etymologizing' rendering of his name: Christo-pher became Christum-ferens (the Christ-bearing one), the first part often spelled as the Christogram (chi-rho): XPO-ferens. It has been speculated that a vignette on the map drawn by the owner and master of the Santa Maria, Juan de la Cosa (c. 1500, mentioned above), depicting St. Christopher as Christ-bearer is in fact a portrait of Christopher Columbus, which would not only have visualized Columbus's crusade-like mission but would also represent the only extant contemporary portrait of the Genoese.[45] In "Columbus' Ultimate Goal: Jerusalem," Carol Delaney goes one step further: citing Columbus's diary she makes the case that his voyage was to serve a larger crusade-like plan that was to raise the money needed for the conquest of Jerusalem, an apocalyptic precondition for the second coming of Christ. However the Spanish monarchs positioned themselves to this ultimate purpose, we can at least state that they embraced the Christian mission of the undertaking.[46]

A western route to Asia would not only bypass the (just a decade ago conceded) Portuguese sphere of interest down the coast of Africa, but also find allies and build a strong Christian base in the back of the world of Islam, far enough removed from any Portuguese interests. We need to remember that the European view of the world, that is, the geographic framework within which papal and colonial powers operated, was slowly changing but still largely Ptolemaic at the end of 15th century. While the Portuguese purportedly sought the road to Jerusalem through and around Africa, the Spanish crusade-strategy (read: colonization justification) could be to open a front from East Asia.[47]

After Columbus's return, Pope Alexander issued a series of bulls of which the revised version of the one called *Inter Caetera* (dated to May 4, 1493, and containing revisions certainly petitioned for by either Castile or Portugal or both) introduced a demarcation line running north-south through the Atlantic Ocean that, in extension of the provisions of the *Treaty of Alcáçovas-Toledo* (1479), divided the Ocean into an eastern Portuguese sphere of interest and a western Spanish one. Although later moved a hundred leagues west to properly protect Portuguese interests and more western return routes from Africa to Portugal, this papal 'precept' was adopted a year later in the *Treaty of Tordesillas* (June 7, 1494) and thereby acknowledged by the two major colonizing powers of the late 15th century as political reality.

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[44] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 293

[45] Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 69.

[46] Delaney states: "The 26 December 1492 entry in his journal voyage[...] , written in the Caribbean, leaves little doubt. He says he wanted to find enough gold and the valuable spices 'in such quantity that the sovereigns.., will undertake prepare to go conquer the Holy Sepulchre; for thus I urged to spend all the profits of this my enterprise on the conquest' (Diario 1492[1988: 291]). This statement implies that it was not the first time Columbus had mentioned the motivation for his undertaking, nor was it to be the last. Columbus wanted to launch a new Crusade to take back the Holy Land from the infidels (the Muslims)." Carol Delaney, "Columbus' Ultimate Goal: Jerusalem," *Comparative Studies in Society and History 48*, no. 2 (2006): 261.

[47] France, Crusades and the Expansion of Catholic Christendom, 295.

With papal blessings Spain and Portugal had divided the known world into spheres of crusading/colonizing interests.

Exactly a century after the Portuguese conquest of Ceuta (1415) in northwestern Africa, Pope Leo X issued the bull *Praecelsae Devotionis*, dated November 3, 1514. A century after Ceuta, the world looked radically different: not only had Portuguese and Spanish (as well as less publicized English and French) 'discoveries' expanded European knowledge about the world, but they had also enlarged the territory these early-modern European nations called 'their own,' ranging from Portuguese outposts along the African coast, India, and Malacca to the beginnings of empire-building in Central and South America. Florida as well as the Pacific Ocean had been 'discovered' just the year before (1513). The westward 'discoveries' seemed to prove the spheric nature of the earth: consistent with Columbian assumptions, the Amazon for example, when discovered in 1499, was at first believed to be the Ganges River.

Further westward exploration begged the question, however, where the Pope's demarcation line would run on the other side of the globe, that is, where exactly the Spanish western sphere of interest would ultimately meet the eastern Portuguese one. Early discoveries on the western route to 'India' seemed to confirm even more the Ptolemaic world view, here in particular his gross underestimate of the globe's circumference—Magellan's circumnavigation was still a half-decade in the future—and it must have seemed, especially to the Portuguese, venturing far beyond (the actual) India at this point, a point of real concern where their sphere of interest might end. Pope Leo X was, however, on best terms with the crown of Portugal and had already, in a bull from June 7 of that same year of 1514, extended the spiritual jurisdiction monopoly of Portugal's Order of Christ from Africa to all eastward 'discoveries.' Half a year later, in *Praecelsae Devotionis*, he would then alleviate Portugal's concerns by confining the demarcation line to the Atlantic, removing thereby any possible limitation of Portuguese expansion in Asia.[48] This uncertainty became soon untenable when, in the 1520s, both empires claimed the Moluccas as being in their sphere of interest. It took many years and a bipartisan scientific commission to calculate the extension of the demarcation line to the other half of the globe, which left the Moluccas within the Portuguese sphere. This was affirmed by both powers in the Treaty of Zaragoza (1529).

After these developments, but also after the beginnings of Portugal's American colonial empire since Pedro Alvares Cabral's accidental landfall in modern day Brazil in 1500, the conquests of Hernán Cortés in modern day Mexico and the ensuing expansion and consolidation of New Spain, as well as Pizarro's very recent attack on the Inca and all the abuse on Indigenous populations that went with it, forced the papacy to again confront the question of slavery. In 1537, Paul III issued the papal brief *Pastorale Officium* (May 29) and the bull *Sublimis Deus* (June 2). Just like the bulls *Regimini gregis* and *Creator omnium*, issued a century earlier (1434) by Eugenius IV with respect to the Indigenous populations of the Canary Islands, they forbade the enslavement of the 'Indians' of the South and West, perceived as hampering proselytizing efforts and thereby the expansion of Christendom, for which they had to recognize the full humanity and rational capability of these peoples as precondition for their ability to receive the Catholic faith. And just like in the case of the bulls a century earlier, the papacy reversed course shortly afterwards, in the latter case with a breve (brief) by the same Pope just a year later.[49] [50]

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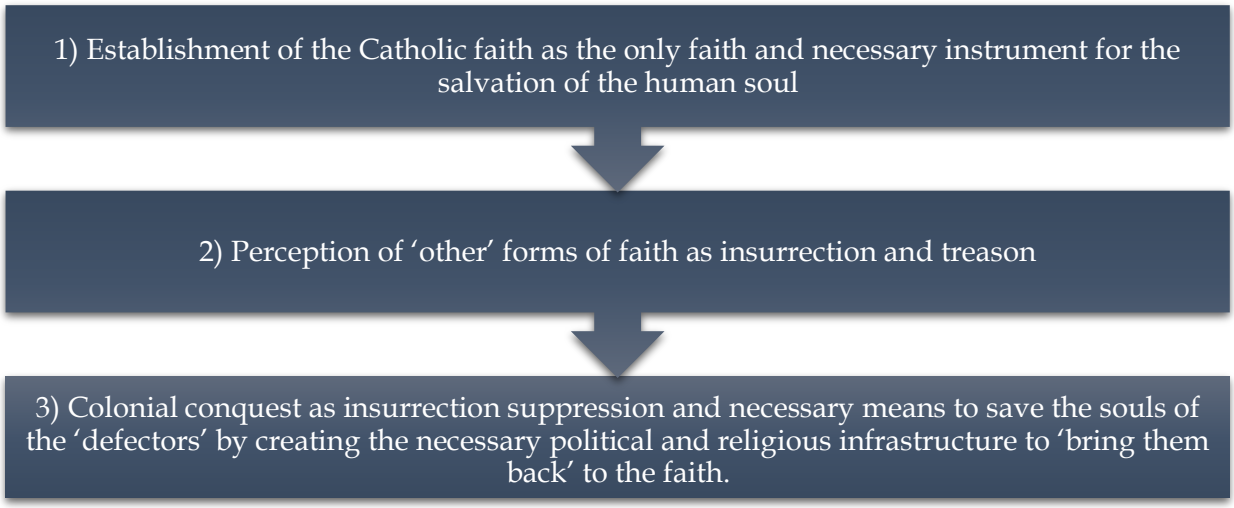
[48] Cf. Davenport 1917, 112–113 for the short introduction to this bull.

[49] Non Indecens Videtur, June 19, 1538.

[50] Cf. Ngata 2022 for a critical view of this papal inconsistency.

The DoCD as 3-step Argument

The present chapter sought to explain the development of the Doctrine of Christian Discovery as it evolved in a series of papal bulls in the context *of* and in dialectical conversation *with* the process of early colonial expansion and its main driving forces. The DoCD is rooted in the tradition of the crusades, which in the form of the Reconquista had been an ideological force and political reality for centuries for the Christian kingdoms of the Iberian Peninsula. It is also rooted in the medieval canon law concept of the papal world monarchy, which secular powers usually tended to ignore, but which for the Iberian crowns became a handy justification tool by which the papacy was able to grant them non-Christian territories around the world, coordinating and embedding the reality of territorial conquest within the framework of the God-intended expansion of Christendom over the globe. According to Church doctrine, this expansion is perceived as necessary for the salvation of the human soul, which is believed to be possible only through the faith in Jesus Christ. Every resistance to this soul-saving expansion (for example, by adhering to beliefs other than *the* "faith itself") is perceived as treason and rebellion. Colonial expansion, it was suggested by the colonizing powers and accepted by the papacy, was the necessary means by which to achieve the ultimate goal of global salvation. The application and Protestant adaptation[51] of this Doctrine shaped the world we live in today.



Conclusion

Within the crusade framework of the early Iberian colonial effort, the papacy emerged as a go-to mitigator of necessarily arising conflicts, as Flores sums up nicely:

The period c. 1430 to 1530 is notable for the friction that emerged between the two empires. Portugal attempted and failed to claim the Canary Islands, while the Catholic monarchs of Spain sought to establish a position in West Africa and in the Atlantic beyond Cape Bojador. These conflicts were resolved through papal mediation and through the signing of the treaties of Toledo (1480) and Tordesillas (1494), which drew boundaries for the spheres of influence of Portugal and Castile through certain lines of latitude and longitude, respectively. More than a

[51] Cf. Brett and Hill 2024, 1–19

quarter-century later, the Spanish interest in the Moluccas and the question of how to define the so-called Tordesillas antimeridian was resolved through the Treaty of Zaragoza (1529) […].[52]

Mediating the interests of the powerful Iberian kingdoms in the language of crusade and mission, the papacy in reaction to their petitions drafted the ideology and rules of colonial conquest, a Doctrine of Christian Discovery that would become political reality through the signing of international treaties. The signing of the *Treaty of Alcáçovas* and the accompanying bull *Aeterni Regis*, issued a year later and explicitly confirming *Romanus Pontifex* (1455) and *Inter Caetera* (1456), represent, in a way, a milestone in the development of the Discovery Doctrine: on the one hand, I would argue, we see here the Doctrine in its mature state – the Reconquista as crusade has been expanded into the (re-conquest) of the world for the rule of Jesus Christ and the one true faith in him, outside of which there is no salvation of the soul. A different faith is not only regarded as no faith at all but perfidy, treason, and rebellion against God's order. The colonial enterprise is framed as a crusade that is paving the way for the spreading of the faith and God's rightful rule.

On the other hand, it is here at the intersection of the *Treaty of Alcáçovas* and the bull *Aeterni Regis* where a doctrine is ostensibly turned into political reality, where two Christian crusading, proselytizing, and colonizing powers apply the *terra nullius* principle in a first definition of geographic interest spheres of 'discovery.' From the perspective of these secular powers, this was meant to ensure that no Christian power prays on another's possessions or claims, and from a papal perspective, that 'crusader energy' was deflected away from potential conflicts between Christian powers towards war against and conquest of 'the enemies of Christ,' that is, the effective expansion of Christendom across the known world.

Developed in a series of papal bulls, the Doctrine of Christian Discovery had matured by the fourth quarter of the 15th century. Accepted by all Catholic parties involved and applied in a secular treaty, it became a principle of international law. In dialectic interaction with new 'discoveries,' later papal bulls will build on this foundation and further develop the Doctrine, developments that will then crystalize in the later treaties of Tordesillas (1494) and Zaragoza (1529). A portolan-style manuscript map by Cantino (1502) shows colonial discoveries, including the demarcation line.[53] The papal bulls born out of a certain worldview had by now themselves shaped the European view of the world, a view that would in turn shape the world—by subjugating it in accordance with the bulls' Doctrine.

[52] Flores, "Iberian Empires," 279.

[53] Thrower, Maps and Civilization, 69.